

In the image on the previous page the hive `HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT` has a key called “*”; this key has a sub-key called “`shellex`”, which in turn has a sub-key called “`ContextMenuHandlers`”, which again has a sub-key called `avast`. The `CA_antivirus` sub-key, created by the anti-virus program, contains values that tell Windows to include it in the right-click context menu. The program will also have other information—stored elsewhere in the Registry—addressing different aspects of the program’s functioning.

Each of the six hives serve a different function, storing information specific to the hive’s function. Thus:

`HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT` contains all the information related to fundamental aspects of the Windows user interface, file association mappings for drag and drop functionality, shortcuts, and OLE (Object Linking and Embedding) information. In XP it is a compilation of the information found in `HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Classes` and `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\Software\Classes`. When a value in a sub-key of the same name is present in both hives, the one in `HKEY_CURRENT_USER` is used.

`HKEY_CURRENT_USER` contains all the information related to the current user logged into the system including such things as Desktop settings, logon names, and other user-specific information. This information is a copy of the currently logged-in user’s configuration and other information merged in from the section of the `HKEY_USERS` hive relevant to the currently-logged in user.

`HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE` contains all the information regarding the hardware, software, and other PC-specific preferences that are common to all the users who log in to the machine.

`HKEY_USERS` contains all the information related to specific preferences of individual users, who are each identified by a unique security identifier called the SID. This SID is unique for the life of the system. If a user is deleted and another created with the